Initially, native Americans were welcoming of Europeans, as evidenced by the alteration of their Creation lore to accommodate the existence of the White Man. However, as contact and trade increased between the two groups, the native gradually saw his land being lost to the European to cover the debts incurred in the course of trade,[19] and as the coloniser's greed for native land increased, conversion to Christianity did too. At the very least, serious efforts were invested by Christian European missionaries to map local traditions and deities onto Christianity to reconcile the two and gradually ease the native into the coloniser's religion. Conversion to Christianity was also projected to the native as a way of gaining social respectability, acceptance into the circles of the coloniser and access to European education being offered by missionaries. This meant that Christianity satisfied the practical needs of the native peoples, needs which were created by the coloniser, instead of fulfilling their spiritual needs.

In her paper 'The Impact of Colonial Contact on the Cultural Heritage of Native American Indian People', Nassima Dalal suggested that evangelical attempts to convert indigenous populations had more than one objective. The first was, of course, to spread the word of the Gospel and the second was to acquire the land of indigenous populations.[20] Some would say it was the other way around and that religion was used as a means to an end,[21] the end being integration of native peoples into European culture and complete elimination of the native culture.[22] This was achieved through several means, one of which was to massacre vast numbers of the community, and to ensure that the rest of the community fell in line they were forced onto reservations with minimal resources. In some cases diseases, such as smallpox and the plague, were introduced with the knowledge that the indigenous community was not immune to them.

There are recorded instances of 'voluntary conversion' by indigenous peoples when the threat of confrontation with the coloniser loomed large. The hope was that such conversions to Christianity would prevent violence and start a dialogue between the communities. Clearly, such conversion was seen as the only alternative to annihilation. Notwithstanding such attempts to make peace with the 'civilised' Christian coloniser, literature tells us that just about 10 per cent of the native population survived European diseases, massacres, displacement and assimilation[23] which wiped out most of its bearers of tradition and knowledge.[24] In contemporary discourse, it is sometimes argued that the little that survives of indigenous tradition is